DANTE

Science Fiction / Tragic Romance

My name is Dante, and I built a time machine, it took more than thirty-three years of my life and cost me nearly three billion dollars.

But before you decide that I'm either the greatest genius who ever lived or a complete lunatic, you should probably know why I built it. So let me take you back to the beginning.

I was born in 1978. My father named me Dante after Dante Alighieri because he adored *The Divine Comedy*. My father was a pioneer in technology, a giant in his field, and he was determined to teach me everything he knew, and I hated him for it.

While other children were allowed to be children, I was expected to learn. Science, mathematics, engineering. He made sure my mind was never allowed to rest, and for years, it created a wall between us, I wouldn't understand how valuable everything he taught me was until much later.

And then there was Nikita, by our final year at university, my future seemed almost embarrassingly simple. I loved her, I intended to marry her, that was it, I have never understood the way people speak about love as though it is something temporary. They fall in love, fall out of it, find someone else, marry, divorce, try again, I never wanted that, I wanted one woman, one life, nikita.

Then, during our final year, my father became terminally ill. I knew how it would end before the doctors finally admitted it, strangely enough, I accepted his death, don't misunderstand me. I wasn't cold, and I wasn't ungrateful. My father had lived a long life. He had achieved almost everything a man could reasonably hope to achieve, It was simply his time. so I spent as much time with him as I could, until that day, the day everything went wrong, my father died before I could get home, I was furious, not at him, not even at death, I was furious at myself for not being there, I told them not to announce his death until I returned, which meant no one at university knew what had happened.

They only knew that Dante was in a foul mood and apparently wanted to be left alone, Nikita didn't leave me alone, she approached me and asked if I could drive her to her grandmother's house near the complex.

I refused.

She immediately knew something was wrong, that was Nikita, she looked at me for a few moments and somehow understood that it had something to do with my father. She tried to ask me what had happened,I wouldn't answer, then she put her arms around me, She wasn't asking for anything, She wasn't trying to fix anything, She simply wanted to comfort me.

And I pushed her away, harshly, I can still remember her face, I can remember the place, I can remember almost every word, there are moments your mind preserves with perfect cruelty.

Nikita left.

She decided to walk to her grandmother's house instead, She never made it, a car hit her on the way, that was the last day of Nikita's life. I had accepted my father's death almost immediately, I hated that I hadn't been there when it happened, but I understood death. My father was ill. His body had reached its limit. There was nothing left for me to fight.

Nikita was different, so when Andrei told me she was dead, I knew he wasn't lying, but I couldn't accept it, not emotionally, not intellectually, not in any meaningful sense of the word, there had to be something I could do, there had to be some way to save her, logic told me otherwise, science told me otherwise, the entire structure of reality told me otherwise, she was dead.

Gone.

And dead people do not come back, but there was one thought I couldn't endure. The last time I had seen Nikita was in that damned alley near the complex, she had tried to comfort me, and I had rejected her, that was it, that was supposed to be the final chapter of our story.

A bad day, a cruel response, a walk she should never have needed to take, and then nothing, no proposal, no wedding, no life together, no second chance for me to tell her I was sorry. Just a grave

I refused, you can call it grief, you can call it guilt, you can call it obsession, perhaps it was all three, but I knew one thing with absolute certainty, I was going to change what happened, even if the entire world told me it was impossible, so I made a decision, I would build a time machine, and I would save Nikita, after graduating with my degree in mechanical engineering, I began working, before long, I realised I had solved only half the problem.

I knew how to build machines, I didn't yet know how to make one violate time itself, so I started again. I studied theoretical physics, years passed then more years, I did little besides study and work, there was only one night each year that belonged to anything else.

Halloween.

Every Halloween, I visited Nikita's grave. I would sit beside her and tell her how much I loved her and how much I missed her, and how I was going to bring her back, I refused to speak about her as though she were truly gone, because as far as I was concerned, she wasn't, not yet.

After earning my second degree in 2010, I became CEO of my father's company.

That gave me something I hadn't possessed before, Resources, Money, Technology.

People who would follow my instructions without needing to understand why, and somewhere beneath the legitimate work of the company, I began my real project.

My life's work.

How to build a time machine.

Years became decades, failure followed failure, the world changed around me,I grew older, Nikita remained exactly as I remembered her, and then, on the fifth of May, 2042, I stood before the machine that had consumed more than thirty-three years of my life, It worked, I didn't test it, I didn't ask anyone else to test it.

I hadn't sacrificed my youth, my fortune and most of my life just to let some bastard accidentally become the first human being to travel through time, besides, I already knew exactly where I wanted to go.

Not to see the dinosaurs or to witness the birth of civilization or even to meet some great historical figure.

I wanted one ordinary day.

One alley.

One conversation.

One woman walking toward her grandmother's house.

Thirty-three years earlier, Nikita had asked me for a ride, and this time, I was going to say yes.